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News briefs

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Massachusetts Gov. Healey increasingly criticized over migrant crisis

BOSTON — A top Democrat who helped lead a series of legislative oversight hearings on the COVID-19 response by former Gov. Charlie Baker's administration criticized Gov. Maura Healey for not using typical emergency supports or coordination tools to manage Massachusetts' shelter crisis.

Rep. William Driscoll, a fourth-term Democrat from Milton, said the state has reached a point "where a pivot is necessary and overdue." Nearly 6,400 families are in an emergency shelter system that is propped up on stilts by a vast net of hotels and motels — a structure that is contributing to a $45 million monthly tab.

A unified command structure supported and facilitated day-to-day by experienced staff needs to be established, Driscoll said in a letter to Healey Monday. The administration "appears to be hastily adapting to the day-to-day operations of multiple agencies across multiple secretariats to attempt a version of crisis response," he wrote.

Healey declared a state of emergency last month as the emergency shelter system started to strain with newly arrived migrants and sky-high housing costs. The administration projects about 1,000 families, including locals who are experiencing homelessness and newly arrived migrants, to enter the state's emergency shelter system each month.

—Boston Herald

Student's tip leads to firearm being found at NC elementary school

RALEIGH, N.C. — A gun was found at a Wake County elementary school on Tuesday thanks to a tip from a student.

In a message sent to families at Lead Mine Elementary School in Raleigh, Principal Jena Wojdylo-Kehler said a student reported to a staff member Tuesday afternoon that another student was in possession of a firearm.

"We immediately notified law enforcement and WCPSS Security," Wojdylo-Kehle said. "The firearm was quickly confiscated from the student."

She said that all students are safe at the school, located in North Raleigh.

Wojdylo-Kehle said a thorough investigation by law enforcement and district security revealed that the student did not mean to bring harm to the school. Instead, the principal said the student was showing the firearm to classmates.

Under state law, a student who brings a firearm to school is required to be suspended for 365 days. The person who allowed the student access to the firearm could also face criminal charges.

—The News & Observer

Ban on 'toxic' food additives heads to California governor's desk

A ban on several food additives found in popular snacks, including Skittles, passed its final vote in the California Legislature on Tuesday, sending the bill to the desk of Gov. Gavin Newsom.

The California Food Safety Act — the first of its kind in the country — would ban the manufacture, sale or distribution of brominated vegetable oil, potassium bromate, propylparaben and red dye No. 3.

The first version of the bill also proposed a ban on titanium dioxide, but the substance was not included in the version that passed the state Senate by a 33-3 vote on Monday.

The bill, introduced by Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Woodland Hills, passed a final procedural vote Tuesday back in the Assembly on its way to the governor.

If signed, the law would take effect on Jan. 1, 2027, and impose fines of up to $10,000 for violations.

Gabriel noted that many of the chemicals included in the bill had already been banned in other countries, with manufacturers using alternative substances.

—Los Angeles Times

Netanyahu’s challenge to court power faces judges’ scrutiny

In arguments watched live across the country, Israel’s top judges sparred with government lawyers on a controversial law passed by Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu’s right-wing coalition that limits the court’s power.

The case — brought by opposition lawmakers and watchdog groups — is one of the most momentous in the nation’s history and, for the first time, all 15 Supreme Court justices took part on Tuesday. A ruling isn’t expected for weeks but their questioning suggested that they consider overturning the law to be well within their power.

The law, passed in July as the opposition walked out in protest, bars judges from voiding government policies or decisions they deem “unreasonable.”

“We are talking about the reasonableness clause, which has been with us for decades,” Supreme Court President Esther Hayut told the government’s advocate, Ilan Bombach, her voice rising in frustration. “You’re blocking all courts from coming to the aid of litigants who are asking us to intervene with this clause. You are saying the courts can’t even discuss this. There are thousands of detailed decisions by ministers that affect the daily life of citizens.”

This is the first of a number of judicial changes the government promised when it took office in late December, a populist overhaul that has split the nation, driven millions into the street, sparked criticism from the White House and battered markets.

—Bloomberg News

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